



The Mendenhall Glacier

A partially hollow glacier close to the Alaskan city of Juneau, best known for its extraordinary blue ice caves

The Mendenhall is one of 38 large glaciers that flow down off the Juneau Ice-field. The glacier is about 13 miles (21 km) long and ends in an iceberg-filled lake. It has been retreating and shrinking since at least the 1700s, with some phases of rapid retreat in recent years, and it is expected that it will recede out of the lake by about 2020.

Exploring the glacier

By paddling a canoe across the meltwater lake, it is possible to reach the side of the glacier's terminus, clamber across its surface, and then explore its ice caves, with their deep blue ceilings and streams of water running over the rocks inside. Wildlife in the area includes beavers, bears, spawning salmon in season, and the occasional wolverine (a carnivore resembling a small bear).



▷ BLUE DESCENT

An ice climber descends through a moulin into one of the large ice caves in the glacier.

◁ ICE PROWLER

Occasionally, a wolverine is spotted in the area. It is thought that wolverines use glaciers for temporarily storing killed prey.

MELTWATER DRAINAGE

The lower parts of many glaciers have extensive systems for draining meltwater. These include vertical channels, called moulin, and streams at the base. Changes in the drainage pattern can cause outlet channels to dry up, leaving them as internal ice caves, as in the case of Mendenhall.

